

Moshe Szyf: Inheriting Trauma

Reflect

- Which do you think plays a greater role in shaping us: nature or nurture? Why?
- The field of epigenetics demonstrates that early social life experiences not only impact us emotionally but they also change the actual structure of our DNA. To what extent were you surprised by this finding? What questions does it raise for you?
- Various parts of the Bible present a communal understanding of sin — that is, the sin of one person is “visited upon” (Exodus 34:6-7) future generations. How has Moshe’s talk changed the way you understand this idea?

Respond

- Where in your own community or family have you seen the effects of trauma impacting subsequent generations?
- If Moshe’s research is correct, what difference would it make in how we understand our responsibility to address social problems?